

REAL WORLD

Number symbols

Many civilizations developed their own symbols for numbers, some of which are shown below, together with our modern Hindu–Arabic number system. One of the main advantages of our modern number system is that arithmetical operations, such as multiplication and division, are much easier to do than with the more complicated older number systems.

Modern Hindu–Arabic	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Mayan	•	••	•••	••••	—	• —	•• —	••• —	•••• —	=====
Ancient Chinese	一	二	三	四	五	六	七	八	九	十
Ancient Roman	I	II	III	IV	V	VI	VII	VIII	IX	X
Ancient Egyptian										∩
Babylonian	𐎶	𐎵𐎶	𐎶𐎵𐎶	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶	𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵𐎶𐎵

▽ Triangular number

This is the smallest triangular number, which is a positive whole number that is the sum of consecutive whole numbers. So, $1 + 2 = 3$.

▽ Composite number

The number 4 is the smallest composite number—a number that is the product of other numbers. The factors of 4 are two 2s.

▽ Prime number

This is the only prime number to end with a 5. A 5-sided polygon is the only shape for which the number of sides and diagonals are equal.



△ Fibonacci number

The number 8 is a cube number ($2^3 = 8$) and it is the only positive Fibonacci number (see p.171), other than 1, that is a cube.

△ Highest decimal

The number 9 is the highest single-digit whole number and the highest single-digit number in the decimal system.

△ Base number

The Western number system is based on the number 10. It is speculated that this is because humans used their fingers and toes for counting.